

Information Organization Visit Report

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For my information organization visit report I chose to visit The Athenaeum of Philadelphia. I had previously been to an event that was held there and was very curious about how the organization was structured when I found out it was membership based. I reached out to the librarian, Jill Lee, and went to the Athenaeum in person to discuss the organization and her role.

The Athenaeum of Philadelphia was founded in 1814 at a time predating free libraries, when information was limited to institutions like colleges (The Athenaeum of Philadelphia, 2024). The Athenaeum hosts a variety of resources like current books, archives, special collections, rotating exhibits and events to engage the community. As a historic institution in the modern age, Jill explained how the collection works to straddle both interests. “We kind of have two parts of our collection. We have the circulating collection, and then we have the research and reference collection. A little over half of our collection circulates, but then we have things from our founding 200 years ago” (J. Lee, personal communication, October 10, 2024). The Athenaeum of Philadelphia also contains The Regional Digital Imaging Center which Jill explained is highly popular among local artists looking to make copies of their works, and other institutions around the United States working to digitize their records.

When asked about what her specific role was in such a dynamic institution, Jill gave me both a very detailed look into her day-to-day responsibilities, along with an overarching look at the larger projects she’s worked on at the Athenaeum. Jill is a Drexel MLIS alumnus and has been with The Athenaeum of Philadelphia since 1998. She took over the main

library desk in 2008 (The Athenaeum of Philadelphia, 2024). Currently, she oversees purchasing for the circulating collection, manages the circulation desk, and is also involved in various tasks like working events and pop-up exhibits. Because of the size of the Athenaeum and how small the staff is, the website only lists 15 employees of which only four staff members are listed as librarians, Jill described an environment that allows for a very personal relationship with the members of the library. She explained “somebody called the other day, and our assistant librarian was covering Monday evening, and they just told her that I would know what kind of books they liked and to mail them some” (J. Lee, personal communication, October 10, 2024). She described an environment where members trust her to know their personal tastes, and provide recommendations based off her memory of what they’ve borrowed in the past.

Jill was also responsible for transitioning the Athenaeum from an old card catalogue system to an online system when she was first hired. She described the months long process of transitioning over to online as “not too bad. They had been cataloguing their books in original OCLC and then RLIN, so they were printing cards, but that meant that there were electronic records with OCLC and with RLIN. So, it was a matter of getting those records out and uploaded into the system” (J. Lee, personal communication, October 10, 2024). Since then, she’s continuously worked to migrate to newer catalogues like Ex Libris, Aleph, and Alma before the Athenaeum worked out a partnership with the University of Pennsylvania. The Athenaeum’s collection is now hosted on the University of Pennsylvania’s catalogue, where both institutions have access to each other’s resources.

Because of the membership aspect, a large portion of our conversation centered around how having to serve paying members affects different aspects of the Athenaeum. One of the things that we discussed was the diversity of the members. Because I was conducting my interview in the lounge, the informal setting allowed for Alexa, the Development and Membership Associate, to chime into the conversation. Alexa Perillo, who is also a Drexel alumnus and holds a bachelor's degree in Entertainment and Arts Management, was sitting at the front desk and helped provide a more in-depth depiction of what the breakdown of membership diversity looked like. When asked about the breakdown among categories like, age, race, and education level, Alexa explained that the Athenaeum had to straddle a line of wanting to collect data for their own statistics, but also feeling like asking things like age and race on the membership form felt awkward. Currently the Athenaeum does not keep track of racial demographics. When I referenced their strategic plans to diversify their membership, Alexa clarified that they have been working on diversifying the age ranges of the members (The Athenaeum of Philadelphia, 2021). This was done by adding lower tier memberships for students and young adults. Among the young members, Jill did mention an uptick in racial diversity. However, half of the members fall into the shareholder membership category which requires a one-time payment of 500 dollars along with yearly dues. This tended to mean that these members were older with not much racial diversity. The staff at the Athenaeum are very aware of their need to meet their strategic goals to connect with a more diverse community to continue to grow. As Abram (2024) states, "one way to critically assess the organization's capacity to anticipate and respond to a changing world is through strategic planning" (p. 30).

The membership aspect also had me questioning how having members who were lifelong learners willing to pay to seek out information affected my understanding of the role of the library in information literacy. As opposed to public libraries where programs are dedicated to making sure members were information literate, did the Athenaeum see themselves as having opportunities to provide instruction in information literacy as well? Jill discussed how the Athenaeum might not necessarily have moments where they worked with members to connect them to information like how to vote but, there were still opportunities to help members connect to information in situations that required the older members to access information online. While they knew what information they were looking for, older members didn't necessarily have the digital literacy skills needed to operate online. "We don't really get the question of how do I renew my passport or how do I register to vote. They're logged into that. But at the front desk, they'll get a lot of can you register me for this program or these events even though it's online to register" (J. Lee, personal communication, October 10, 2024). The conversation reminded me that information needs are contextual and shaped by individual and social situations (O'Brien et al., 2022). The need for information institutions to help visitors access and process information will always be there, it will just look different depending on the context.

I wrapped up the discussion by asking Jill what she felt was the biggest challenge for the Athenaeum moving forward. Jill felt like the current biggest challenge was having such a small staff trying to keep up with both an influx of new members and all the events scheduled to continuously engage with the community. Alexa mentioned that membership at the Athenaeum had increased by 500 people in the last year. For Jill, this meant that this

was 500 more members, she felt she had to serve with the same number of staff. The staff often felt pulled in too many directions to manage the resources and programming, but also understood that as a membership institution this was what was required to continuously attract and engage with members.

References

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